

STANDPOINTS, PERSPECTIVE AND EPISTEMOLOGY



PLAN OF LECTURE

- Epistemology and Its Problems
- A world designed for men?
- Standpoint Epistemology
- Situated Knowledge
- Different standpoints and perspectives.

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- **THE ANSWER IS THAT: a perspectival approach to knowledge can produce more not less objectivity!**

REMEMBER THESE BIFURCATIONS? THIS WEEK WE ARE LOOKING AT SCIENCE AND OBJECTIVITY

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| • Mind | Body |
| • Rational | Irrational |
| • Culture | Nature |
| • <i>Science</i> | Superstition |
| • <i>Objectivity</i> | Subjectivity |
| • Men | Women |

I WILL START WITH THE IDEA OF EPISTEMOLOGY

- Epistemology is concerned with knowledge
- How we know
- What do we know?

DO YOU KNOW THAT BIG BEN IS IN LONDON?
HOW DO YOU KNOW THIS?



PROBLEMS WITH TRADITIONAL EPISTEMOLOGY...

Most philosophers and scientists and sociologists (in the West) have been men.

As Sandra Harding puts it, this means that the concerns, the topics and procedures of science, philosophy and much social theory are 'man-made' (as Dale Spender pointed out about language too)

This means that both the subject matter of science and what the methods to investigate them are, to a greater or lesser extent, "man-made".



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- **“We should construct new feminist modes of knowledge” - Harding**
 - **Feminism is crucial in advancing knowledge by producing new and better forms of knowing.**
 - **This is not about undermining knowledge, epistemology or objectivity...**
 - **IT IS ABOUT PROVIDING BETTER, MORE ROBUST FORMS OF KNOWLEDGE.**

WHY DOES EPISTEMOLOGY MATTER?

And this applies not just to “feminist”
epistemology
But also to other marginalized or excluded
groups

FEMINIST STANDPOINT EPISTEMOLOGY

IN BRIEF



In any historical period, the prevailing world view reflects the interests and values of the dominant group

Groups traditionally excluded from power occupy a special social position that gives them a privileged epistemological standpoint/a less distorted world view

(We looked at this last week, when we talked about women's experience and Nancy Hartsock).

A WORLD DESIGNED FOR MEN?

- Crash-test dummies were first introduced in the 1950s
- Based around the 50th-percentile male.
- The most commonly used dummy is 1.77m tall and weighs 76kg
- When a woman has a car crash she is 47% more likely to be seriously injured than a man
- 17% more likely to die
- The notion of “Reference Man”
- A Caucasian Man weighs 70kg “and his superpower is being able to represent humanity as a whole. Of course, he does not.” (Perez, 2019)

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- Most PPE (medical equipment designed to protect doctors and nurses) is based on the sizes and characteristics of male populations from Europe and the US.
 - Employers often think that when it comes to female workers all they need to do is to buy smaller sizes.
 - This is not the case....

A WORLD DESIGNED FOR MEN?

- Standard office temperature was developed in the 1960s around the metabolic resting rate of the average man. A recent Dutch study found that the metabolic rate of young adult females doing office work is significantly lower
- Men and women have different immune systems and hormones, which can play a role in how chemicals are absorbed. But medicines and their doses are designed around this notion of “REFERENCE MAN”.
- Bags of cement
- Bricks...



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- *Invisible Women: Exposing Data Bias in a World Designed for Men* by Caroline Criado Perez (2019).
 - Here is a link to an extract-
 - [Perez on a World Designed for Men](#)

FEMINIST INTERVENTIONS

- Critique of the male bias in social research
- ‘Objectivity is male subjectivity’ (Spender, 1980) – critique of objectivity in the positivist tradition
- Emphasis on knowledge as partial, situated and constructed

– NANCY HARTSOCK – MATERIALIST FEMINISM AND STANDPOINT THEORY

1. Men's and women's understandings of the world are different because of the work they do ("in" and "out" of the "home") – because of their different level of access to the public space.
2. The views of the dominating group attempt to structure the world for everybody

WE NEED TO “CHANGE” PERSPECTIVES

3. Because it reveals the partiality of the dominant (male) vision of social relations, feminist standpoint provides a way of moving beyond existing gendered social relations – and this is liberating

KEY POINT! Dominated groups don't automatically have the most objective views of the world; a 'standpoint' is an achievement, won from political struggle; production of knowledge inseparable from political struggle



TO READ LATER....

- A Standpoint is not simply an experience....
- **“it is not the experiences or the speech that provides the grounds of feminist claims; it is rather the subsequently articulated observations of, and theory about, the rest of nature and social relations...that look at the world from the perspective of women’s lives.” Harding, 1991: 124**

PERSPECTIVES

- A perspective (in the sense we are talking about) is not just a viewpoint on the world (but it will involve a view)
- It is not subjective
- It is not imaginary
- It is experienced (and felt)
- Perhaps by a group of people
- But it needs to be “discovered” or “articulated.
- All this does not just have to apply to “women” or “woman”
- The concept of “standpoint” or perspective could help us develop knowledge from other “oppressed” or neglected positions

PAUL GILORY - THE BLACK ATLANTIC

- 'The time has come for the primal history of modernity to be reconstructed from the slaves' point of view'
- Think of Dussel and Howard French
- The early stages of this module were an attempt to start rethinking modernity from a different perspective



GILROY ON “STANDPOINT”

- ‘In terms of contemporary politics and social theory, the value of this project lies in its promise to uncover both an ethics of freedom to set alongside modernity’s ethics of law and the new conceptions of selfhood...that are waiting to be constructed from the slaves’ standpoint’.

BELL HOOKS ON THE OPPOSITIONAL GAZE

- “When thinking about black female spectators, I remember being punished as a child for staring, for those hard intense direct looks children would give grown-ups, looks that were seen as confrontational, as gestures of resistance, challenges to authority. The “gaze” has always been political in my life ...Afraid to look, but fascinated by the gaze. There is power in looking.’ (hooks, 1992: 115)



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- ‘the first time I read in history classes that white slave-owners (men, women, and children) punished enslaved black people for looking, I wondered how this traumatic relationship to the gaze had informed ... black spectatorship’ (hooks, 1992: 115)
 - ‘The politics of slavery, of racialized power relations, were such that slaves were denied their right to gaze’ (hooks, 1992: 115)

PERSPECTIVES AND POWER

- ‘all attempts to repress our/black peoples’ right to gaze had produced in us an overwhelming longing to look, a rebellious desire, an *oppositional gaze*. By courageously looking, we defiantly declared: “Not only will I stare. I want my look to change reality.” Even in the worse circumstances of domination, the ability to manipulate one’s gaze in the face of structures of domination that would contain it, opens up the possibility of agency.’ (hooks, 1992: 116)

THE QUESTION/PROBLEM OF “OBJECTIVITY”....

- I used to start the lecture here!.....

A) TRADITIONAL DEFINITIONS OF OBJECTIVITY (WHICH HARDING MIGHT CALL “OBJECTIVISM”):

- 1) Objectivity, in a philosophical sense, means that there is a real world which exists independently of what humans think or say about it.
- On this view, the task of ALL sciences, including the social sciences is to discover the truth about this external world. It follows from this that one major task facing the social sciences is to develop ways of talking about or researching this external world which will tell the truth about what goes on out there.

THERE IS A SECOND DEFINITION OF OBJECTIVITY

- Methodological Objectivity
 - In this sense objectivity means that the sociologist or researcher should not be biased or let personal opinions affect how they approach the research or the results that they produce. They should be neutral and detached - they should be objective. THEY SHOULD BE VALUE FREE.

HARDING SAYS THAT SUCH APPROACHES TO OBJECTIVITY AND RELATIVISM ARE THEMSELVES BIASED!

- Again - Harding refers to the traditional notion that science (natural and social) should be objective in the sense of value-free and without bias – and not just opinion or simple knowledge claims – as **objectivism**.
- “The concept of value-free, impartial, dispassionate research...has been operationalized to identify and eliminate *only* those social values and interests that differ among the researchers and critics who are regarded by the scientific community as competent to make such judgements.” Harding, 1991: 143